THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH NEWSLETTER

12 Oct 2009

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THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH
NEWSLETTER
OCTOBER 2009

Chairman's Report

A whole legend grew up around the simple expression "Somewhere in France". This was of course how British soldiers writing home in the Great War satisfied the censors by concealing their unit's current geographical position on the battlefield. In much happier circumstances the Paris Branch can now declare openly that we are owners of a new Clubhouse not only "Somewhere in France", but we can be precise: 28, rue des Acacias, 75017 Paris We are keeping our old telephone number: 01.47.42.19.26, and we expect to be reconnected in the week of Monday 12th October.

You will sense the feeling of relief in our Secretary's Report attached, that we are at last coming up the finishing straight. For the Branch archives it will be worth recording here the story of how we came to move after 81 years at rue Boudreau. It is a story of dedicated team-work, so that telling the story will give us the opportunity to thank all those who gave so liberally of their time. Of course I do so at the risk that someone's name will be omitted and if so I apologize in advance. It began with the findings of a working party, chaired by David Edwards, which was set up to propose a Business Plan on the future direction the Paris Branch should take. David Bean, Charles Spencer-Barnard and Nicholas Harding sat on this Working Party. Inevitably they found themselves up against a brick wall: our premises no longer met new Health and Safety regulations, and to carry out the necessary work to bring us into line would cost an estimated 100,000 euros. Not possessing those funds we arrived at the painful conclusion that we had to relocate. The baton was now passed to our Property Member Charles Spencer-Barnard. After a few unsuitable properties had been visited Joan Hicks contacted our member Madame Desaintjean, whose nephew, a Paris estate agent, proposed to us the property at the rue des Acacias. Charles visited this address and recommended to your Committee that it met the search criteria. Our House Manager, David Bean, then took the project in hand, and with extraordinary attention to detail arrived at a definition of what works would be required to give us a result of which the Branch could be proud. Our sale and purchase transactions were not back-to-back. We first sold 8, rue Boudreau to the Maison du Limousin, our neighbours in the building, who kindly allowed us to store our chattels and hold our Committee meetings until we found a new Clubhouse. On purchasing 28, rue des Acacias we gave a mandate to a main contractor for the necessary works to be carried out. In the critical month of August there was a slippage of three weeks before they had agreed terms with their sub-contractors. This held up the project considerably. Meanwhile the Maison du Limousin needed the space at rue Boudreau so that a working party consisting of David and Swee Ching Edwards and Liz Thorn supervised the removal of our chattels to rue des Acacias, where they had to be stored in our cave and in that of the Concierge. As soon as the Clubhouse was ready to receive selected items from storage another working party including David Portsmouth and Tony Bennett brought those selected items up to ground level again, moving the remainder into the Concierge's cave, thus liberating our own cave for upgrading work. Throughout the whole episode the invaluable contribution of your vigilant Branch Secretary and Treasurer needs to be mentioned. Without their readiness to pick up the baton and run with it when required the project would have been impossible to manage. Finally a vote of thanks to our House Manager, David Bean, for his massive contribution in project management during the formative stages. He has now stepped down as House Manger and he can look back on his work with a deep sense of satisfaction.

Thank you all Ladies and Gentlemen. Now we can look to the future in the best of conditions. So do please put the word around that the Royal British Legion is alive and kicking and keen to attract new members. Your Committee will be formulating a Membership drive strategy.

« We will remember them »

SECRETARYS' CORNER

GOODBYE BOUDREAU

HELLO ACACIAS

Well at long last here we are in our new home – 28 rue des Acacias in the 17eme Arrondissement.

Although a bit smaller than rue Boudreau, 28 rue des Acacias is on the ground floor, conforms to the E.U. Health and Safety rules that forced us to move, and is extremely handy for The Arc de Triomphe. We have a lovely kitchen, new bar, toilets and even I get a little niche – I promise to let the other Officers, Membership, Welfare and Social Secretaries in! We also comply by having an emergency exit; what more could we want. What we need now is YOU our members to come by and use your Clubhouse facilities. If we get enough of you wanting to 'pop by' we can arrange to be open more than just once a week. The telephone number will be the same as before – 01 47 42 19 26 – so you can ring and see if we are open.

The nearest Metro/RER is Charles de Gaulle - Etoile. A short walk down avenue Carnot, rue des Acacias is the second turning on the left. We hope to have a Member's Cocktail to formally open the new Legion, so look out for more information at a later date.

In this newsletter you will see the notice for The Poppy Coffee Morning held at the Ambassador's Residence. If you wish to attend, pleas contact Miss Joan Hicks whose details are on the notice.

We follow this a few days later by holding our Annual Service of Remembrance at Notre Dame de Paris Cathedral. We hope to see as many of you at both of these events as possible.

As we have entered the new Legion Fianancial Year, you will see a notice from our Membership Secretary, Mark Yates, reminding you it is time to pay your annual subscription. Please pay your subscription promptly, we do value you as members and hope to encourage more to join us.

All the very best wishes for the forthcoming Legion Year.

Janet Warby	Joan Hicks	Mark Yates
Hon. Secretary	Social Secretary	Membership Secretary

CEREMONY OF REMEMBRANCE AT NOTRE DAME CATHEDRAL 11th NOVEMBER 2009

THE PIPER AND THE PIPES

THE PIPER

Murdoch “Mac” Macleod resigned his Commission in the KOSB Regiment in 2007, retiring as a Lt. Colonel.
Mac was taught to play the Bagpipes in his teens by Pipe-Major Alec Taylor (more on Alec later), lessons were every afternoon for six years. He has played in many countries, some are listed below :
At the White House to President Carter, Regularly at St. Petersburg at British Airways Conventions, South America, Bosnia and Kosovo, Naples (AFSOUTH), Germany (BAOR)

Mac also went and played at the Arctic, where he followed the route taken by an ancestor, Sir Alexander Mackenzie (the first European to cross the American Continent).

On October 4th 2009, Mac ran in the 20 mile Marathon in Edinburgh to raise money for the Army lads who have been seriously wounded in Iraq and Afghanistan.

THE PIPES

The pipes were made by a Scottish firm in 1870. In 1881 they were played by the Gordon Highlanders based in the New Frontier when they took part in the campaign in Afghanistan, marching with pipes playing, the 320 miles from Kabul to Khandahar.
Then they went to the Sudan, floating up the Nile to relieve General Gordon in Khartoum.
In 1889 the Battalion was posted to South Africa and in 1914 to Egypt, then posted to The Netherlands, to fight on the Somme, where they lost 65% of their Officers and 50% of men in three days.

By 1918, the Battalion had lost 27,000 killed or wounded, so pipers were no longer permitted to lead the troops into action, as they lost 16 our of 18 pipers in the first two weeks of action.

In 1936, the pipes were issued to Alec Taylor, but the Battalion was captured in Dunkirk in 1940. A similar fate befell the Battalion when the Japanese captured Singapore, where Alec was among the POW's, the captors insisted that Alec play the pipes to help his fellow prisoners to work harder and longer hours. Alec was liberated two months after VJ Day, one of the lucky ones to survive, he was carried out on a stretcher. There were only 250 survivors of the 1,000 captured.

On their return to the U.K., the Regimental Quartermaster took one look at the emaciated Alec and instead of taking the pipes on Inventory, decided that Alec deserved them, after all he had endured and presented them to Alec.

Alec died aged 60, but shortly before he died, he gave them to Mac saying “if ever the pipes were passed on, it was to be at no cost”. The pipers could never charge a fee!

So much for all the history of the pipes and I must say that Mac never lets them out of his sight, unless they are under lock and key.

Ken Davey



EARL HAIG POPPY APPEAL 2009

LADY WESTMACOTT, wife of H.M. Ambassador to France,

has kindly accepted to host a Coffee Morning

in aid of the Poppy Appeal

which the ROYAL BRITISH LEGION, PARIS BRANCH,

organizes every year for the benefit of the

EARL HAIG BENEVOLENT FUND

The Coffee Morning will take place at

THE BRITISH AMBASSADOR'S RESIDENCE

39 rue du Faubourg St. Honoré,

PARIS 8éme

FRIDAY 6th NOVEMBER, 2009

10h30 - 12 noon

Please send your stamped addressed envelope to :
Miss Joan Hicks
6 rue des Petits Prés
78810 Feucherolles

An invitation card for presentation at the entrance will be sent to you. This event is free of charge. Donations welcome. I.D. Cards or Passports required. Numbers limited. Date limit 30/10/2009

5 Dear Member,

Time flies. A perfect excuse to write to you again: We are rapidly approaching the end of the Royal British Legion year and your subscriptions fall due at the end of September.

The exciting move to new premises with all sorts of new possibilities means you're your continued support is even more important for us for the coming year. It should be an interesting one.

The new HQ in Rue des Acacias are taking a little longer to renovate than forecast by the contractors (to everyone's amazement of course) but will be up and running shortly. The latest promise is for the 22 of September… (I like those three little dots the French seem too use more than the British to express a sort of undefined "Hmm") and this enables us to promise you an interesting and enriched social calendar for 2010.

The inaugural event will be for members, of course, to give you an opportunity to evaluate and to suggest ways to get the most from our new facilities. What would you like to see and do there? Your committee wants to know!

Other events will follow, open to everyone, especially potential new members. Do you have friends or relatives you would like to introduce to the RBL?

Once again your Committee would like to pay homage to those of you who continue faithfully to support the cause even though, because of health reasons, or because you live so far away, you are unable to participate actively in our events. The RBL's work is essentially charitable, your contributions are needed and your membership is the more appreciated for its disinterested nature. Even if we don't get to see you often, you are in our thoughts.

Anyway, to return to our muttons, may I ask you to make a special effort to send in your subscription before the end of October so that I can send out your membership cards in good time? You will be glad to note that it has not increased.

Should you lose the attached subscription form you can download another from the rblfrance.org website. You can also get a membership application form there should you find a potential member.

Don't forget to let me know if you have acquired or changed your e-mail address. during the year. The Paris Branch Newsletter can be consulted online. Many members now get it by e-mail. If you don't, and would like to, please let me know (by email) and I shall send you the link as and when new issues come out. If you prefer the paper and ink version – or if the online version is delayed for some reason - you will , of course, continue to receive it by post.

You can send any information to mfyates@gmail.com or to paris@rblfrance.org which is our official email address. Our website can be consulted at http://www.rblfrance.org/ Don't forget: you can also check events etc. on the site.

Subscription forms (with the new address) are included with this newsletter. I look forward to hearing from you all soon.

Best regards,

Mark Yates
Membership secretary

Que le temps passe vite ! Et j'ai déjà l'occasion parfaite de vous écrire encore une fois : L'année de la Royal British Legion s'est écoulée depuis ma dernière lettre et, puisque l'année RBL termine fin septembre, la date de renouvellement de votre abonnement est imminente.

Cette époque mouvementée, avec le déménagement vers la rue des Acacias, présente toute sorte de nouvelles possibilités et, plus que jamais, votre soutien nous est indispensable.

Les délais prévus par les entreprises concernées dans la rénovation des nouveaux locaux se sont avérés optimistes (quelle surprise !). Les travaux seront terminés le 22 septembre, disent-ils maintenant… Toutefois, ce sera certes pour très bientôt et c'est ainsi que nous pouvons vous promettre un calendrier d'évènements enrichi pour l'année à venir.

La célébration de notre aménagement sera réservée aux membres, et ceci sera l'occasion de nous faire parvenir vos idées, vos observations, quant à l'utilisation optimum de nos nouvelles capacités. Que voudriez-vous y faire ? Votre comité s'y intéresse !

S'ensuivront alors rapidement d'autres évènements ouverts à tous, plus spécialement à de nouveaux membres intéressés par les activités de notre association. Avez-vous déjà autour de vous des amis intéressés ? Peut-être serait-ce l'occasion de leur présenter le RBL .

Toutefois, certains parmi nos membres ne peuvent participer activement aux évènements que nous proposons à cause de problèmes de santé, ou parce qu'ils habitent très loin. Votre comité tient à rendre hommage à ceux-ci, qui restent fidèles pour la simple raison que nous sommes une association caritative vouée à une cause qui leur tient à cœur.

C'est pourquoi aujourd'hui, la rentrée étant enfin active, je vous invite à renouveler votre abonnement dès que possible. Les tarifs restant les mêmes que l'année dernière.

N'oubliez pas de me faire savoir si vous avez fait l'acquisition d'une adresse e-mail depuis l'année dernière – ou si vous avez modifié votre adresse. Actuellement un bon nombre de nos membres reçoivent notre « Newsletter » électroniquement et, si cette solution vous intéresse, vous n'avez qu'à me faire parvenir vos coordonnées. Bien sûr, si vous préférez la version sur papier, vous continuerez à la recevoir par la poste.

Pour tout renseignement, vous pouvez me contacter à mfyates@gmail.com ou à paris@rblfrance.org , cette dernière étant notre adresse officielle attachée à notre site web que vous pouvez consulter ici : http://www.rblfrance.org/

Vous trouverez ci-joint le formulaire d'adhésion (avec notre nouvelle adresse) à remplir et à renvoyer avec votre abonnement 2009-2010. A bientôt...

Bien cordialement

Mark Yates
Membership secretary

THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION PARIS BRANCH

POPPY APPEAL ET COTISATIONS 2009/10
POPPY APPEAL & SUBSCRIPTIONS 2009/10

- Normal / *Normale* 46 Euros
- Reduced / *Réduite* (65 and + / *65 ans et* +) 37 Euros
- 25 years and under / *25 ans ou moins* 21 Euros

Poppy Appeal contribution
Don au "Poppy Appeal" .....

Annual subscription
Cotisation annuelle .....

Administrative Fund donation
Don aux fonds administratifs .....

TOTAL .....

Name / Nom .....

Address / Adresse .....

.....

e-mail ……..

Please tick the box below if you require a fiscal receipt and, if so, enclose a stamped addressed envelope.

Veuillez cocher la case si vous désirer un récépissé fiscal et, dans ce cas, joindre une enveloppe timbrée à votre attention.

☐

Please make your cheque payable to the "Royal British Legion".
Veuillez établir votre cheque à l'ordre de "Royal British Legion"

Royal British Legion. 28 rue des Acacias 75017 PARIS . Tel 01 47 42 19 26
Website : http://www.rblfrance.org/ e-mail : paris@rblfrance.org